

The Morning: Weapons of war

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The New York Times
The Morning

March 11, 2026



By Sam Sifton

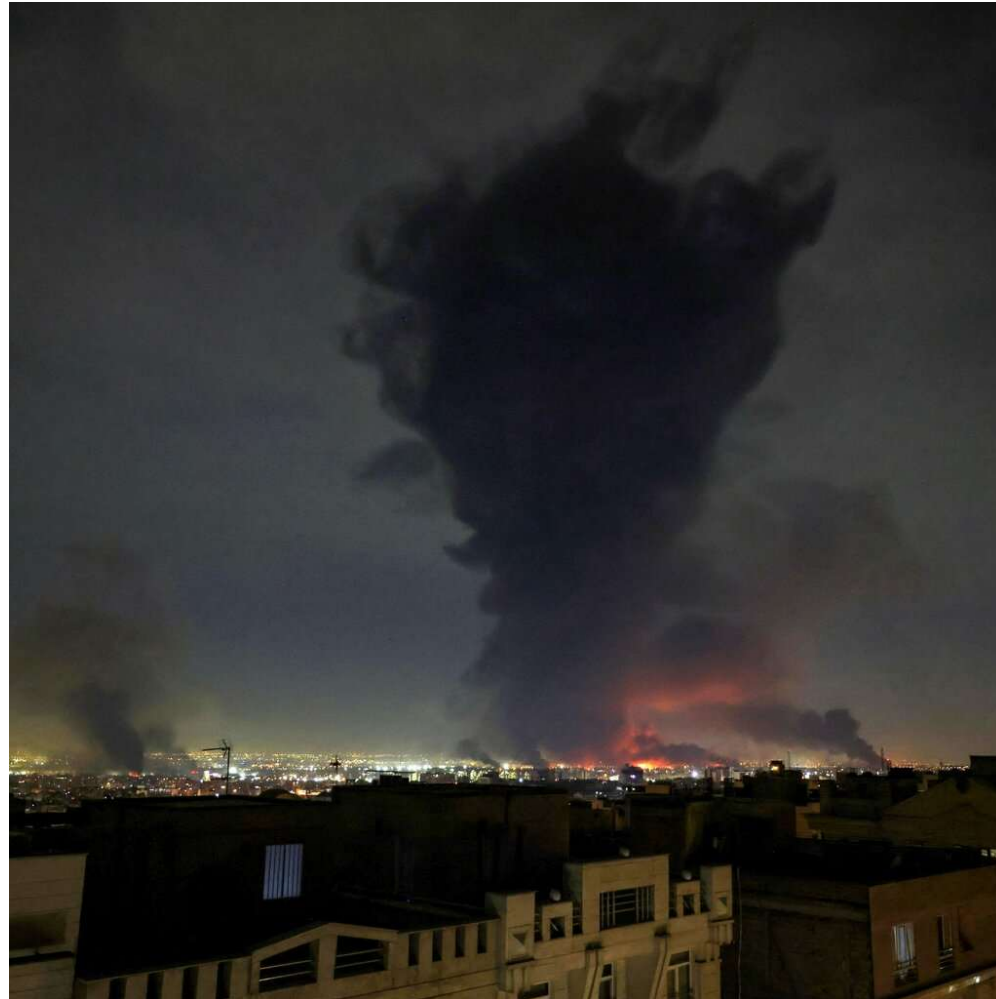
Good morning. Iran’s new supreme leader, Mojtaba Khamenei, [was injured early in the war](#), three Iranian officials told The Times, which could partly explain why he hasn’t been seen since his appointment was announced three days ago.

The war has also damaged some of [Iran’s most cherished cultural treasures](#): a mosque and palaces that have stood for centuries. And Iran’s capital faced [intense shelling](#) yesterday. “It seems they are striking everywhere: homes, schools, mosques, hospitals,” one Iranian told The

Times. “If they keep hitting Tehran like this for another 10 days,” he added, “nothing will remain.”

Each party in this conflict has a slightly different strategy. For the United States and Israel, it’s about overwhelming military force. Iran’s strategy is to saturate the enemy with low-cost drones and missiles and exhaust its resources. Israel and countries of the Persian Gulf are trying to defend against those salvos.

How are nations waging this war? I asked John Ismay, who served for years in the U.S. Navy as a bomb disposal technician and gunnery officer, to explain.



In Tehran on Saturday. Atta Kenare/Agence France-Presse — Getty Images

Weapons of war



By John Ismay
I cover the military.

The war on Iran is being fought not on the ground but in the sky. Here is a guide to the primary weapons each nation is using to achieve its objectives.

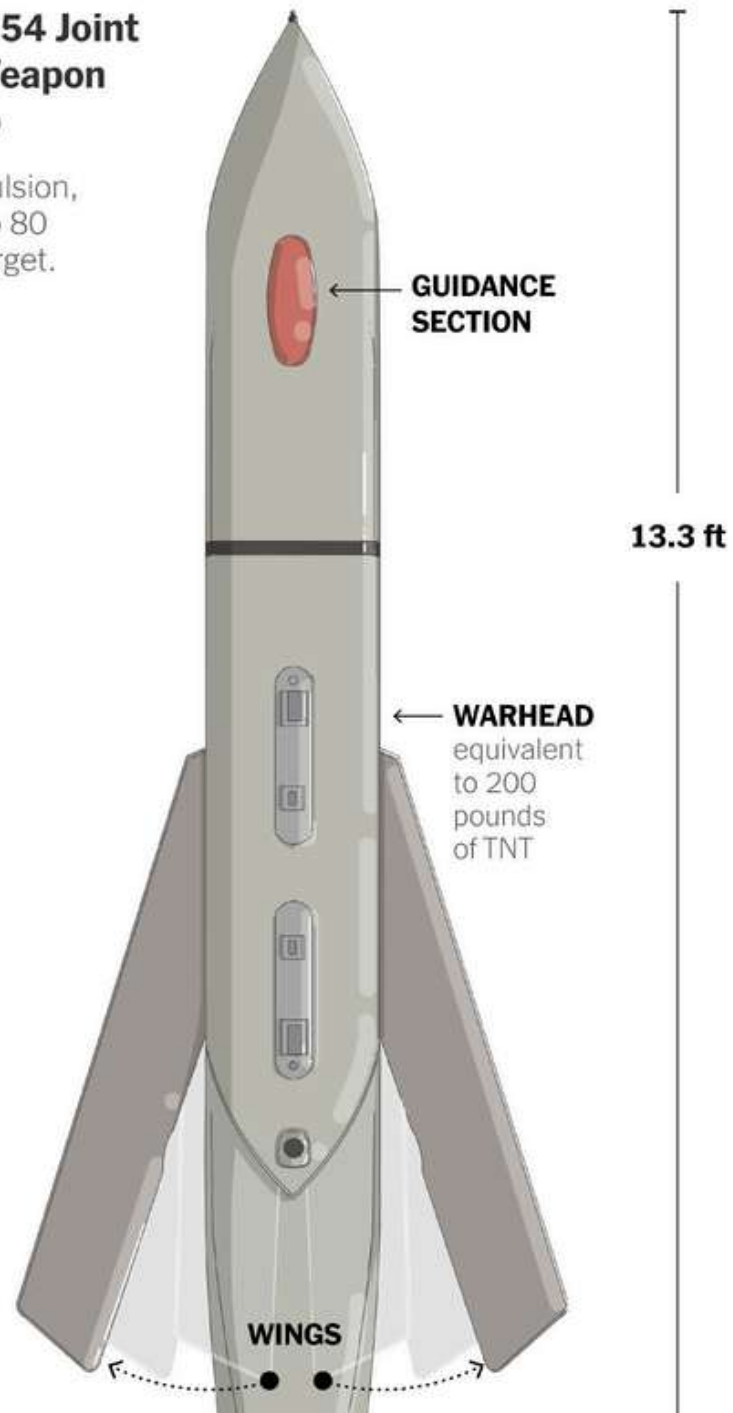
The United States and Israel

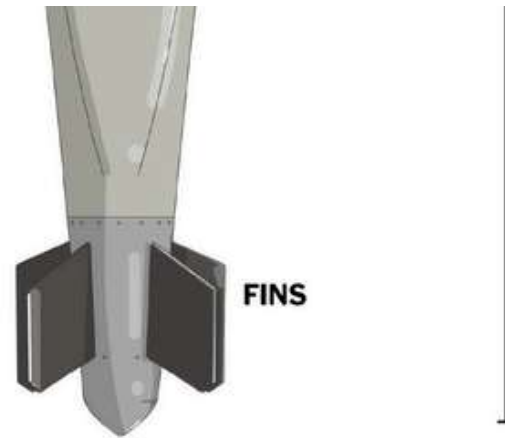
They opened this war by moving two Navy aircraft carriers — along with dozens of Air Force fighters, bombers and refueling planes — into the region. Three destroyers escort each carrier, armed with a variety of offensive and defensive missiles.

When the war commenced, the first wave of the bombardment used weapons, like the AGM-154 glide bomb, that could be launched far beyond the reach of Iran's defenses.

The AGM-154 Joint Standoff Weapon glide bomb

Without propulsion, it coasts up to 80 miles to its target.





Source: U.S. Navy and Development of the Joint Standoff Weapon, a 2006 research paper by K.T. Turco. The New York Times

What it does: When a glide bomb is dropped from a plane like an F/A-18 Super Hornet, the munition's wings swing out, providing lift for a long, quiet flight to its target. Rotating tail fins use GPS to steer the bomb. Some models can hit moving targets.

How far it goes: More than 80 miles.

How it's used: One variant is a cluster weapon that blankets enemy air-defense sites with bomblets. Another version contains a warhead with the equivalent of about 200 pounds of TNT.

Who makes it: Raytheon.

How much it costs: \$578,000 to \$836,000.

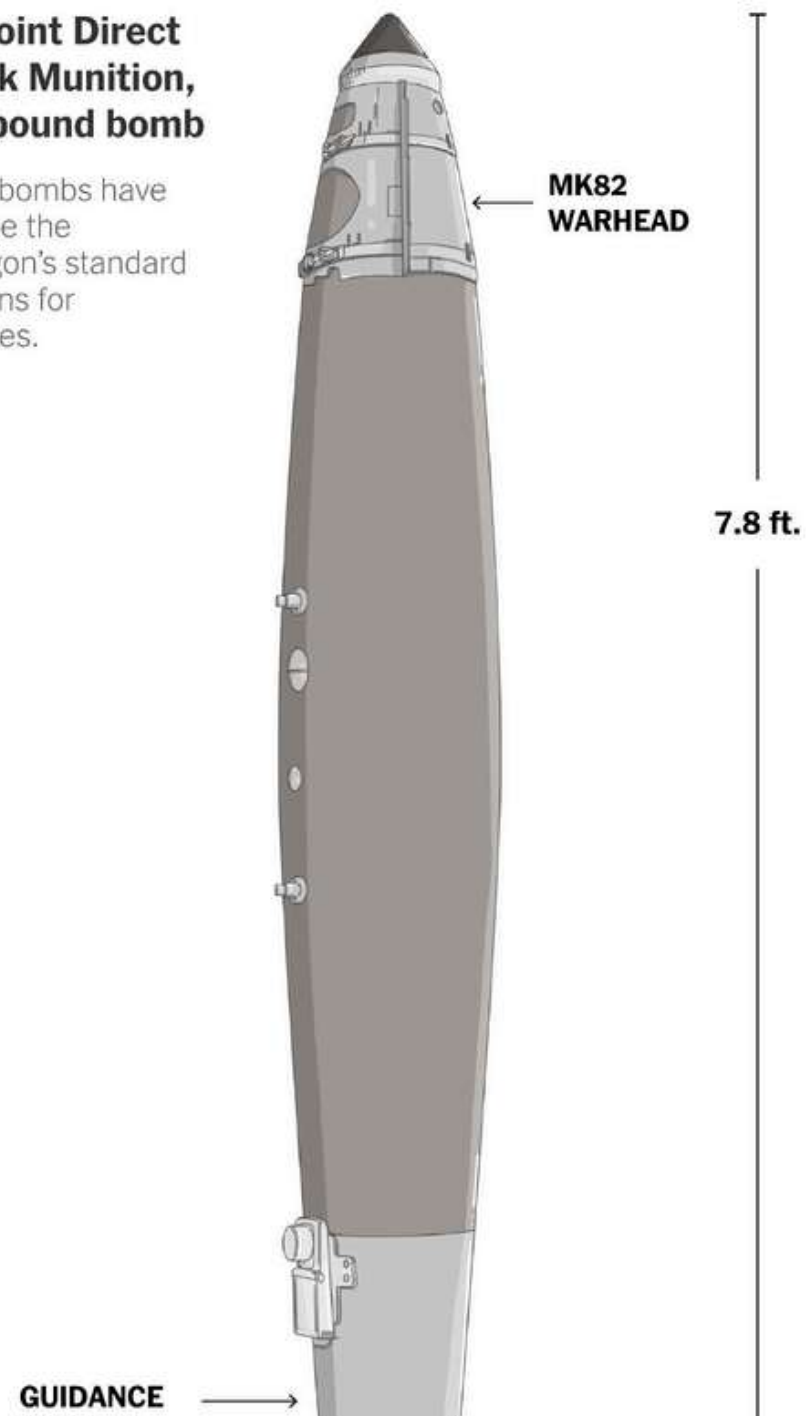
How many the U.S. has: The Navy bought 3,000 of them nearly two decades ago.

Now the Defense Department says the military has destroyed Iran's air defense and will switch to using far less expensive "general purpose" bombs that are

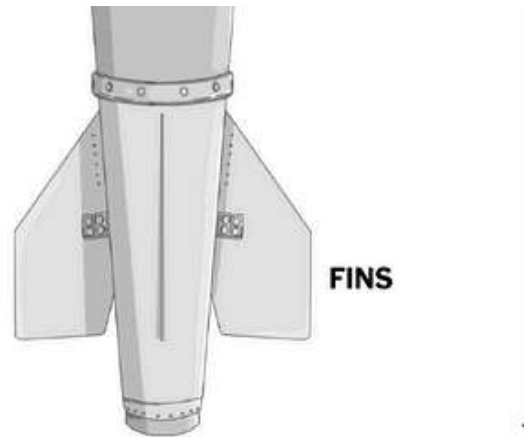
dropped much closer to their targets. They come in three sizes: 500, 1,000 and 2,000 pounds.

The Joint Direct Attack Munition, 500-pound bomb

These bombs have become the Pentagon's standard weapons for airstrikes.



SECTION



Source: U.S. Air Force and Beyond Precision, report by Tyler Hacker, Center for Strategic and Budgetary Assessments. The New York Times

What it does: It falls down and blows things up. It is guided by GPS signals and can be programmed to explode just above its target or on impact.

How far it goes: Depending on the altitude of the aircraft that drops it, this weapon can travel up to 15 miles.

How it's used: Of the three sizes of warheads available, the 500-pound version is most commonly used. Designed to work in all kinds of weather and cost about half the price of laser-guided bombs, the Joint Direct Attack Munition became the Pentagon's go-to tool for airstrikes during the post-Sept. 11 wars. These bombs land within about 30 feet of their targets with roughly 200 pounds of explosives.

Who makes it: Paligen Technologies and Boeing.

How much it costs: The warhead costs about \$1,000, and the guidance kit runs about \$38,000.

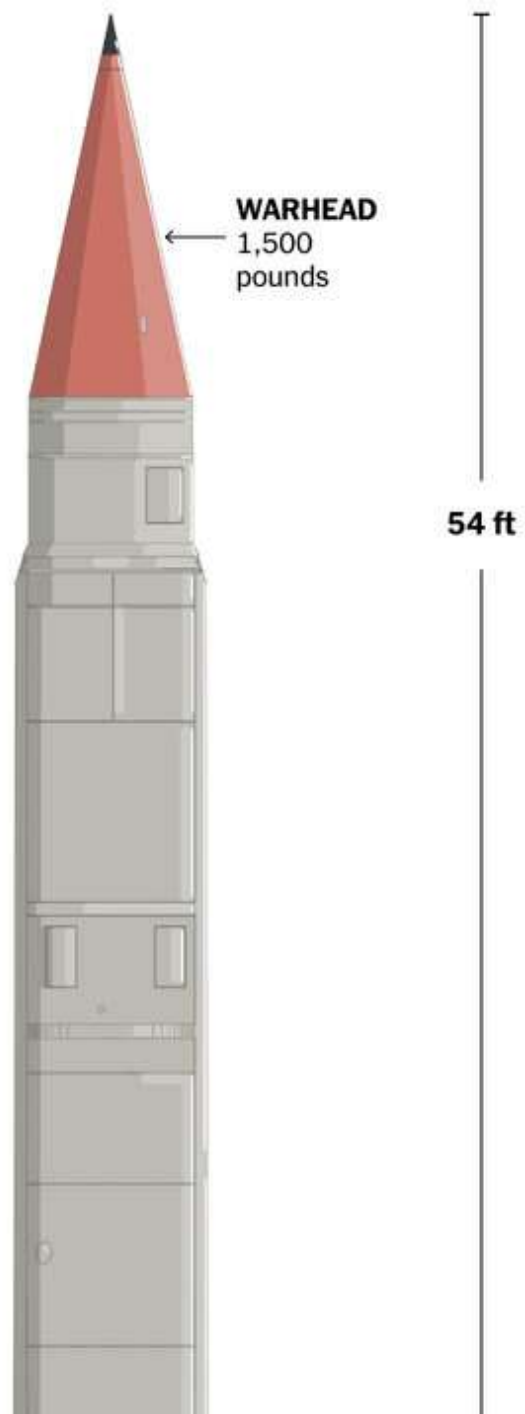
How many the U.S. has: Likely hundreds of thousands.

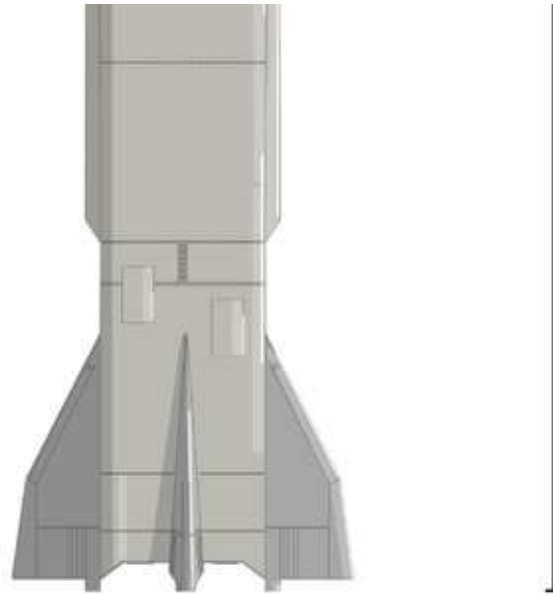
Iran

Commanders there are fighting back with missiles and drones across the region. They don't have much in the way of air defenses or an air force anymore. Their main offensive weapons are medium-range ballistic missiles like the Shahab-3.

The Shahab-3

This midrange
ballistic missile
flies into space.





Source: Open Source Munitions Portal. The New York Times

What it does: It launches from the ground and flies up to 250 miles above the Earth's surface, where there's less aerodynamic drag. Then it arcs down and falls toward its target.

How far it goes: More than 1,200 miles.

How it's used: These missiles have aimed at cities in Israel and infrastructure across the Gulf — refineries, air-defense radars and military buildings. The Shahab-3 is believed to be accurate to roughly 150 feet and carries a 1,500-pound warhead.

Who makes it: Iran's Aviation Industries Organization. It's based on North Korea's Nodong missile.

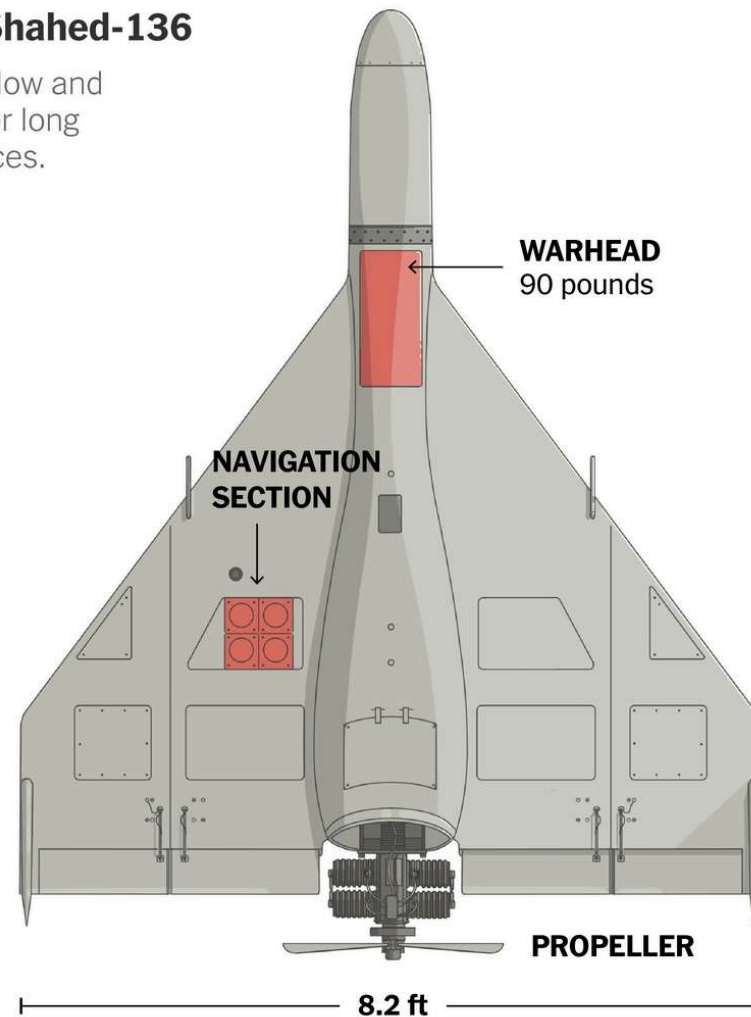
How much it costs: Unknown.

How many Iran has: Unknown, but U.S. intelligence agencies say Iran's arsenal of medium-range ballistic missiles is "substantial."

To avoid the countermeasures that intercept and destroy their missiles, Iranians also use drones. The main one is the Shahed-136.

The Shahed-136

It flies low and slow for long distances.



Source: Open Source Munitions Portal. The New York Times

What it does: It's essentially a crudely made, propeller-driven cruise missile.

How far it goes: Up to 1,500 miles.

How it's used: The Shahed-136 is slow (about 115 miles per hour), but it flies at a low altitude, making it difficult to spot by radar. The drone uses GPS to find its target, and the 90-pound warhead explodes on impact.

Who makes it: Iran Aircraft Manufacturing Company.

How much it costs: \$35,000, analysts think.

How many Iran has: Likely thousands.

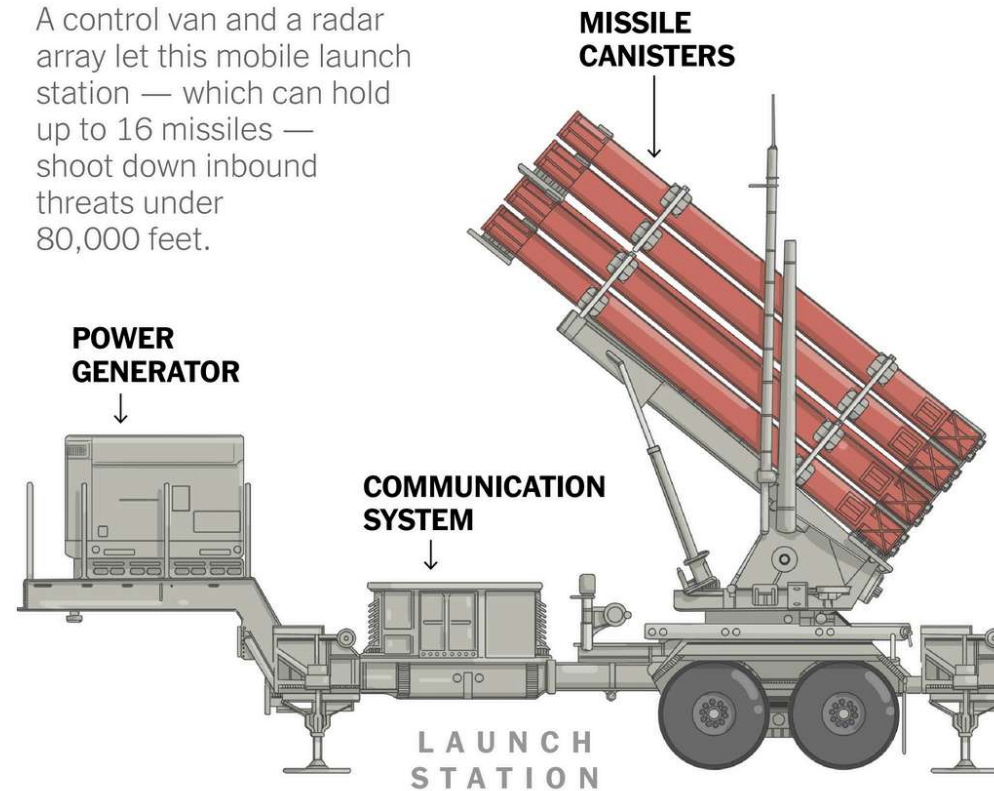
After a Tomahawk missile destroyed a girls' school in southern Iran and killed dozens of students, President Trump said the weapon may have been Iran's. But only a few nations possess the Tomahawk, and the Islamic Republic is not known to be one of them.

Persian Gulf nations and Israel

These countries are on the receiving end of Iran's retaliatory strikes, so they've been working to shoot down drones — the tech for this is evolving rapidly — and missiles. Their most reliable tool is the Patriot system.

The Patriot

A control van and a radar array let this mobile launch station — which can hold up to 16 missiles — shoot down inbound threats under 80,000 feet.



Source: Center for Strategic and International Studies and the U.S. Library of Congress. The New York Times

What it does and how it works: A Patriot battery consists of a control van and one or more missile launchers and radars. When the radar spots an incoming threat, soldiers make the decision to shoot or not, based on where it's heading.

What it defends against: The Patriot can shoot down planes, helicopters and missiles up to an altitude of 80,000 feet. There are three different Patriot missiles for different kinds of targets. (You don't use the same weapon to strike

a slow-flying aircraft and a ballistic missile moving at five times the speed of sound.)

How it's used: Patriots create a bubble of protection — up to 100 miles in any direction — around high-value locations such as government buildings, military sites and power plants.

Who makes it: Raytheon.

How much it costs: \$2 million to \$4 million per missile.

Who has them: In the Middle East region, Bahrain, Israel, Kuwait, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates.

To account for attacks from Hamas and Iran, Israel developed the most robust air-defense network in the Middle East — much of it designed and made domestically. The Pentagon even purchased one Israeli system, called Iron Dome, for its own use.

More on the war

The Iranian military is adjusting its tactics to target American [air-defense and radar systems](#) as well as hotels frequented by American troops. [See where U.S. sites have been hit.](#)

The U.S. said it had [attacked 16 Iranian mine-laying vessels](#) near the Strait of Hormuz amid concerns that Iran could use mines to block the world's access to oil.

The Constitution gives Congress the power to declare war, but presidents have increasingly claimed that power for themselves. In the video below,

Charlie Savage, a national security reporter, explains how they find their legal justifications. **Click to play.**





The New York Times



THE LATEST NEWS

Elections

Mississippi: Representative Bennie Thompson, 78, [fended off a primary challenge](#) from Evan Turnage, a 34-year-old lawyer who made Thompson's age an issue in the race.

Georgia: A special election to fill the seat of former Representative Marjorie Taylor Greene is [going to a runoff](#). Shawn Harris, a Democrat and retired Army officer, will face Clayton Fuller, a Republican endorsed by Trump.

Politics

The Trump administration said it needed a list of Jews at the University of Pennsylvania to investigate antisemitism. A judge is considering [whether the demand went too far](#).

Attorney General Pam Bondi has [moved into military housing](#) because of threats. Others in the administration, including Stephen Miller and Marco Rubio, have done the same.

Senate aides are now allowed [to use three A.I. chatbots](#) for official work.

Around the World

South Korea: A concrete runway barrier, built to save costs, may have [contributed to the deaths of 179 people](#) when a plane made an emergency landing in 2024.

Australia: One member of the Iranian soccer team who requested asylum in the country after a silent protest during a match changed her mind and [asked to return home](#).

China: For years, the military flew jets near Taiwan almost daily. Now the flights have stopped, and [some analysts are asking why](#).

HUMAN OR MACHINE?

Artificial intelligence is already writing romance novels, academic papers and software applications. And while some people doubt that A.I. can take on

creative work, several recent studies suggest that, in blind tests, many prefer A.I.-generated writing to human-authored works.

A new quiz by Kevin Roose and Stuart A. Thompson puts that to the test. They asked A.I. to find examples of strong human writing, in a range of styles and genres, and then to craft its own version using its own voice. In the quiz, you'll choose which you prefer, and then learn whether a person or a machine wrote it. Start with the example below:

The boy asked his grandfather why the old church had no roof. The old man said weather and time and indifference. The boy asked if someone could fix it. The grandfather said yes. But no one would. Things were built and things fell down and mostly people just stepped over the rubble on their way to somewhere else.

Passage A

It makes no difference what men think of war, said the judge. War endures. As well ask men what they think of stone. War was always here. Before man was, war waited for him. The ultimate trade awaiting its ultimate practitioner. That is the way it was and will be.

Passage B

Which do you prefer?

[Passage A](#)

[Passage B](#)

OPINIONS

If Trump wants to ensure Americans have cheap energy, even during times of war in the Middle East, he should [embrace renewable sources](#), **Natasha Sarin** writes.

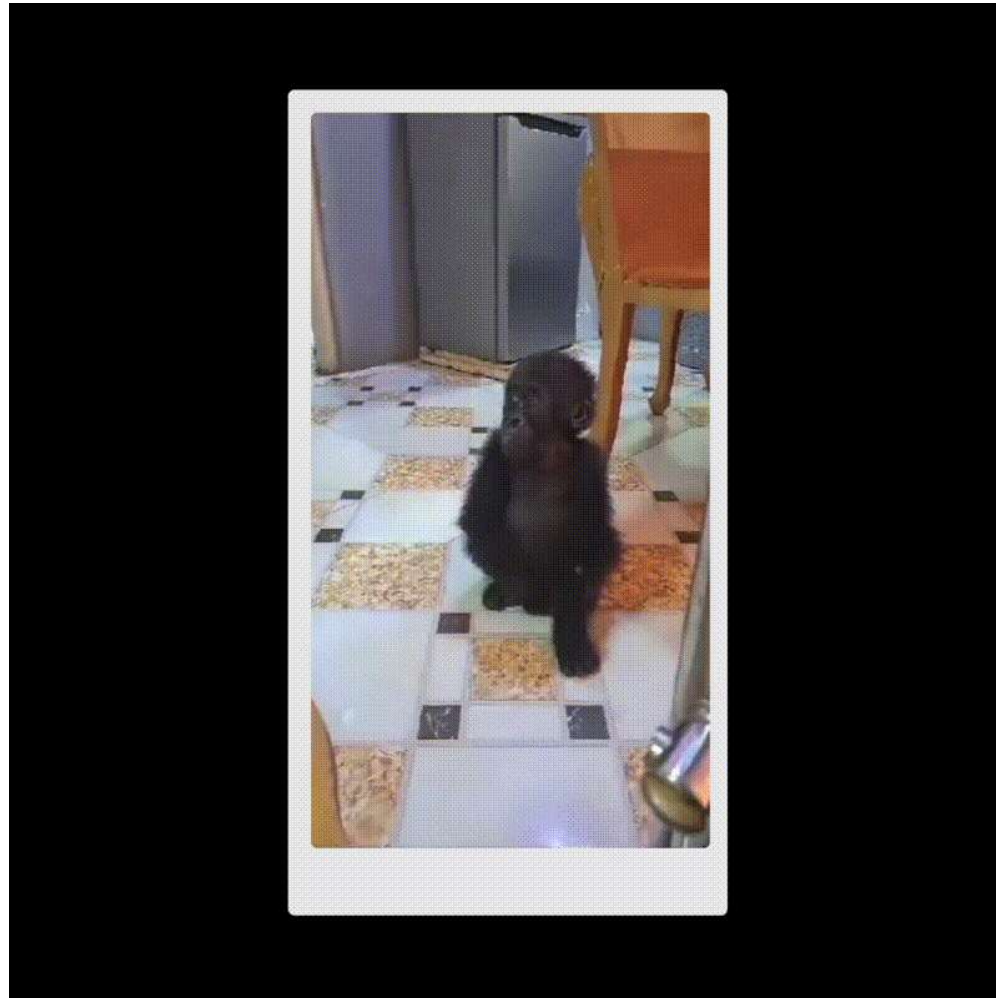
Here is a column by **Bret Stephens** on [four ways the war in Iran could end](#).

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MORNING READS



The New York Times

Endangered species: Social media is driving an illegal trade in infant gorillas. [Here's the story of how one was saved.](#)

Avatar influencers: Companies [are increasingly using A.I.](#) to create realistic figures to market their products to specific audiences.

Your pick: The most-clicked link in The Morning yesterday was [about bad film casting](#).

TODAY'S NUMBER

170,543

— *That was the average number of exits from Bay Area Rapid Transit stations in January 2026. In January 2020, it was 388,910. “The very future of the familiar white and blue trains, which have zipped around the Bay Area since 1972, is in doubt,” [The Times reports](#).*

SPORTS

N.B.A.: Bam Adebayo [scored 83 points](#) during the Miami Heat's 150-129 win over the Washington Wizards yesterday. Only Wilt Chamberlain has scored more points in a single N.B.A. game.

N.F.L.: Maxx Crosby is staying with the Las Vegas Raiders. An agreement [to trade him to the Baltimore Ravens fell apart](#) after he failed his physical, league sources said.

RECIPE OF THE DAY



David Malosh for The New York Times. Food Stylist: Rebecca Jurkevich.

Add a bag of tteok — Korean frozen rice cakes — to your freezer and you'll be able to knock out countless easy weeknight recipes, including this delightful number from Eleanore Park for [miso rice cakes with spinach and peas](#). The cakes absorb the miso sauce beautifully and provide heft against the sweet pop of the peas and mineral softness of the spinach. The recipe's vegan, but if you're not, stir in a half-pound of shrimp toward the end. Regardless, I'd shower the

whole situation with herbs, cilantro and mint in particular, and serve with a bowl of chile crisp for heat.



THE REINVENTOR





Amy Harrity for The New York Times

Michelle Pfeiffer, 67, was a movie queen who stepped away from Hollywood to raise her family. Now she's reinvented herself as a small-screen star, with two new streaming shows coming this month, "The Madison" and "Margo's Got Money Troubles." Over lunch in Santa Monica, Calif., Alexis Soloski, who covers the arts, talked with her about them. "If you're going to survive, you're going have to figure out a way to do this and enjoy your life and not disappear," Pfeiffer said. [Read the interview here.](#)

More on culture

At the Metropolitan Opera this week, the soprano Lise Davidsen sang the role of Isolde in Yuval Sharon's new staging of Wagner's "Tristan und Isolde." Our critic Joshua Barone [gave it a rave](#). The production, he wrote, "ushered in a new era at the Met, showing how a fresh and promising generation might stake its claim to the core repertoire and shape the years to come."

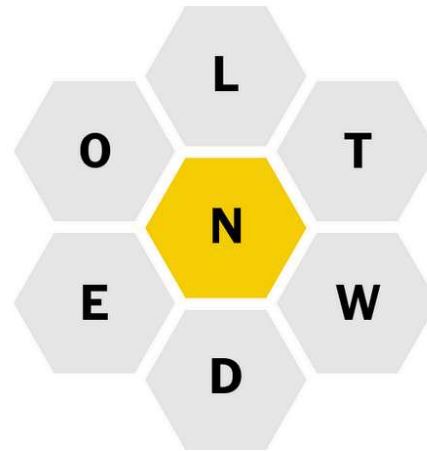
"In the Days of My Youth I Was Told What It Means to Be a Man" is about Tom Junod's relationship with his swaggering, traveling handbag-salesman father. Jennifer Szalai, a book critic, has [a riveting review](#). Junod, for his part, [told The Times](#) he had been writing the story for decades, trying to get it right. "You heard him, you smelled him, you loved him, you hated him, you feared him," he said about his dad.

THE MORNING RECOMMENDS

Engage yourself — and then send your friends this list of [wedding registry must-haves](#) from the ordained officiants at Wirecutter. (Or don't, and buy yourself a salt pig or cast-iron pan.)

Exercise your whole body quickly with [combination exercises](#).

GAMES



Here is [today's Spelling Bee](#). Yesterday's pangrams were *cormorant* and *monocrat*.

And here are [today's Mini Crossword](#), [Wordle](#), [Connections](#), [Crossplay](#) and [Strands](#).

***Thanks for spending part of your morning with *The Times* and me.
See you tomorrow. — Sam***

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